

China Oil Product Monthly

China's crude oil imports fell sharply in April; focus on refined oil export policies

Equities

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Crude oil imports -20% YoY; domestic oil product demand still weak

Affected by geopolitical tension in the Middle East, China's crude oil imports fell 20% YoY to 38.47m tonnes in April, the lowest level since July 2022. The utilization rate of major domestic refineries fell to 70.8% (vs. a 2025 average of 80%). That said, China's crude inventory has remained relatively stable since March (~1.3bn bbl, equivalent to 76 days of crude oil demand and >100 days of crude oil imports). Gasoline and diesel inventory remains high. We believe this is mainly due to: 1) high oil prices significantly dampening domestic gasoline and diesel demand; and 2) restrictions on refined oil exports. In the near term, with a sharp rise in crude import official selling prices (OSP) and freight/insurance premiums, coupled with weak domestic product demand, domestic refiners face significant pressure. Thus, we remain cautious on the domestic refining sector. Moreover, we advise monitoring adjustments to oil product export policies.

Major refineries' utilization down to 70.8%; May oil product exports to rise a bit

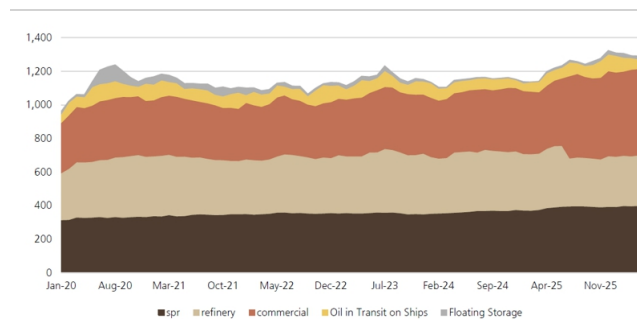
Oil product prices: In April, the domestic retail price ceilings for gasoline/diesel had one increase and one decrease, with cumulative cuts of Rmb135/t and Rmb130/t. Due to persistently weak demand, market average prices fell nearly Rmb1000/t and Rmb300/t.

Utilisation: Affected by the disruption to Middle East crude supply, major refineries' utilization fell 5.9ppt MoM to 70.8% in April. Shandong independent refinery utilization was relatively stable, up 0.8ppt MoM to 55.2%. **Oil product exports:** To ensure domestic energy supply, China suspended oil product exports in March. However, according to a Reuters [report](#), China approved 0.5m tonnes of exports to non-Hong Kong regions in May (doubling from April and c30% of pre-Iran conflict level). We believe that is mainly due to still-weak domestic oil product demand and high inventory pressure for gasoline and diesel.

Middle East refining exports/capacity impact

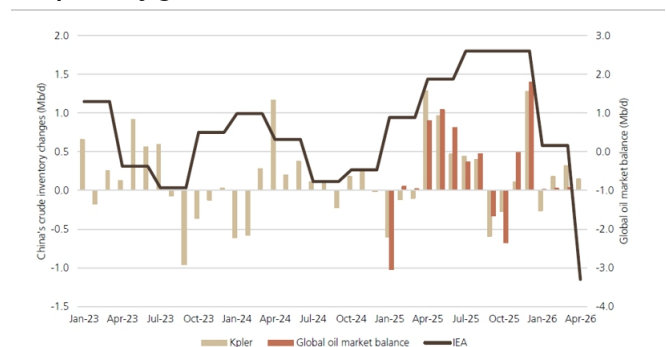
UBS estimates that, even assuming SPR releases at the maximum pace, the outright shortfall of product exports from the Middle East would be ~3.5Mb/d. According to a recent expert call (see [note](#)), the actual SPR releases on the crude and product sides may turn out slower and more challenging; thus, the actual shortfall could be higher than theoretically. Additionally, the crude shortfall is likely to translate into similar cuts to throughput, so ~9Mb/d of the shortfall could become visible on the product side. UBS estimates that due to strikes/attacks, >3.5Mb/d of refining capacity in the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) has halted operations, >2Mb/d of which could be damaged and require some sort of repairs. For context, at the peak of the drone attacks at Russian refineries in fall 2025, UBS estimates <1Mb/d of refining capacity was affected, significantly below the current scale of the impact in the Middle East. UBS estimates GCC refineries are likely to run at ~50% capacity, on average. Beyond the Middle East disruption, March-April are typically the peak of scheduled maintenance for global refineries. Coupled with intensified drone attacks at Russian assets, a fire at the 120kb/d Geelong refinery in Australia, as well as a workers' strike at the Whiting refinery, based on Kpler data and UBS estimates, offline capacity globally may have exceeded ~12Mb/d in April (see [note](#)).

Figure 1: China's crude oil inventory (Mb)



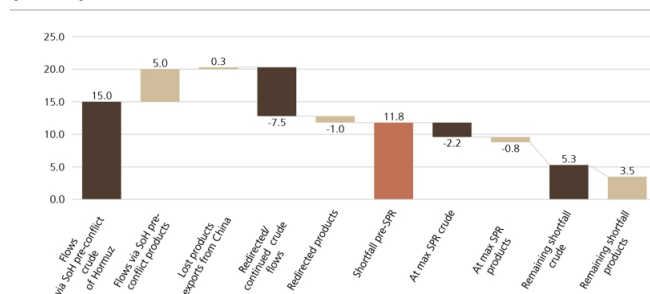
Source: Kpler, UBS

Figure 2: Monthly changes in China's crude oil inventory, vs. quarterly global crude oil market balance (Mb/d)



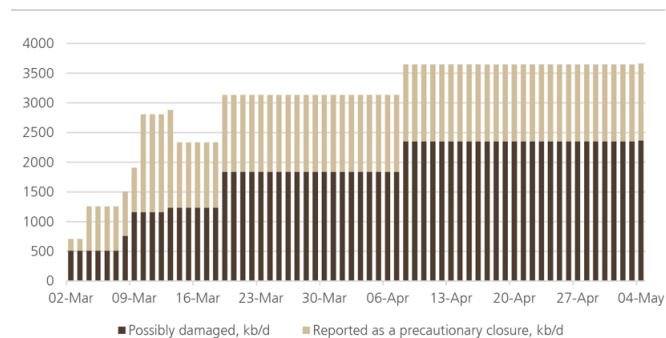
Source: IEA (2026) Oil Market Report - February 2026, Kpler, UBS. Note: IEA's China crude oil inventory data available from January 2025.

Figure 3: Refined product flow affected by the Middle East (Mb/d)



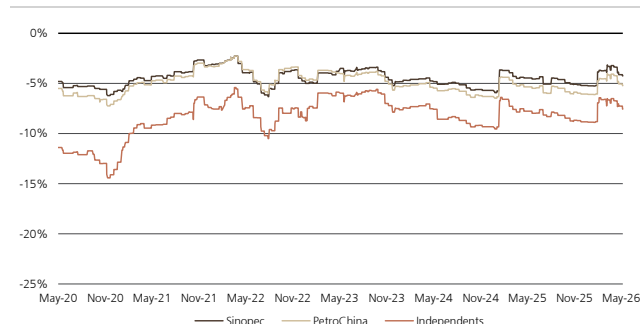
Source: Kpler, IEA, UBS

Figure 4: Capacity in GCC affected by attacks



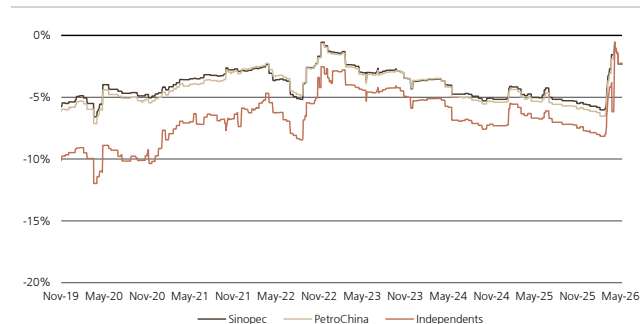
Source: Media reports, UBS estimates. Note: GCC refers to the Gulf Cooperation Council.

Figure 5: China weighted average realised retail price discounts to NDRC ceiling – gasoline (92)



Source: UBS Evidence Lab (> [Access dataset](#)), 315i, NBS, Reuters

Figure 6: China weighted average realised retail price discounts to NDRC ceiling – diesel



Source: UBS Evidence Lab (> [Access dataset](#)), 315i, NBS, Reuters

	Apr 25	May 25	Jun 25	Jul 25	Aug 25	Sep 25	Oct 25	Nov 25	Dec 25	Jan 26	Feb 26	Mar 26	April 26
Sinopec													
Shandong													
Hebei													
Tianjin													
Henan													
Anhui													
Beijing													
Shanxi													
Jiangsu													
Hubei													
Liaoning													
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Zhejiang													
Fujian													
Sichuan													
Guangdong													
Guangxi													

Key: Color coding for realized retail product price percentage discounts to NDRC benchmark prices.

-1%
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-3%
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-9%
-10%
-11%
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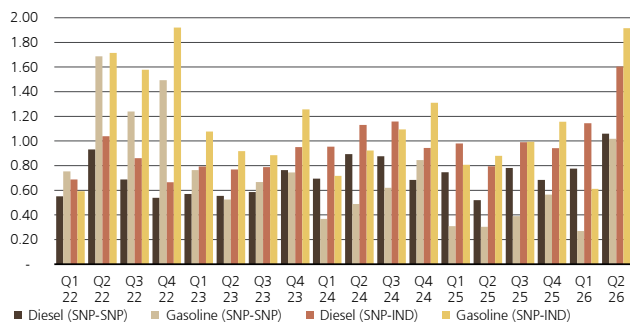
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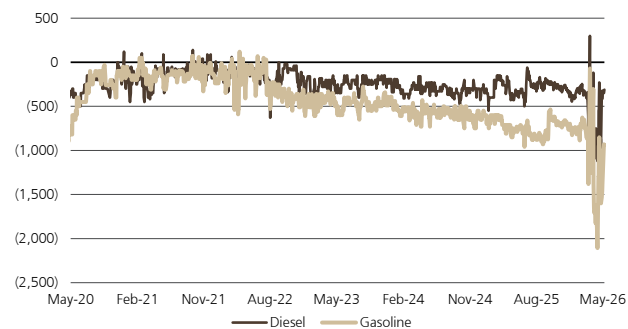
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Figure 9: Estimated spread of SNP (Sinopec) realised retail oil product price to wholesale price (Rmb/litre, quarterly, Shandong)



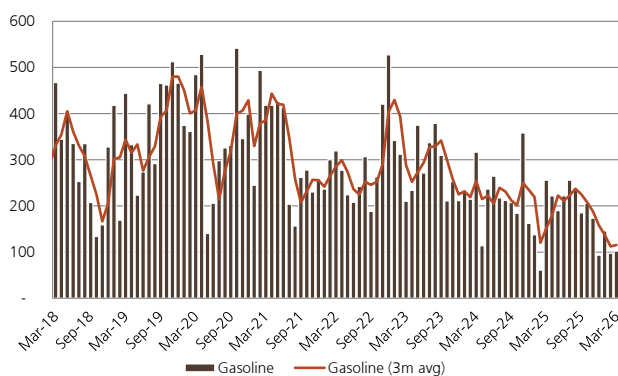
Source: UBS Evidence Lab (> [Access dataset](#)), 315i, Wind

Figure 10: Shandong independent wholesale oil product price discount to Sinopec (Rmb/t)



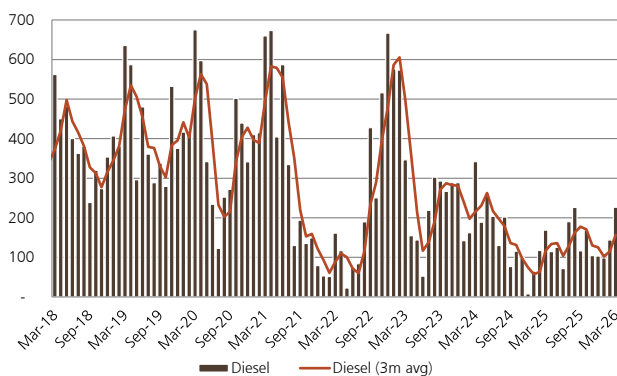
Source: UBS Evidence Lab (> [Access dataset](#)), 315i, Wind

Figure 11: China's gasoline net exports (kbpd)



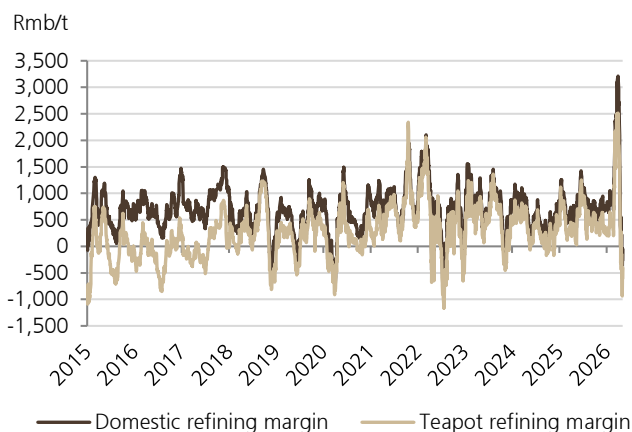
Source: General Administration of Customs of China (GACC)

Figure 12: China's diesel net exports (kbpd)



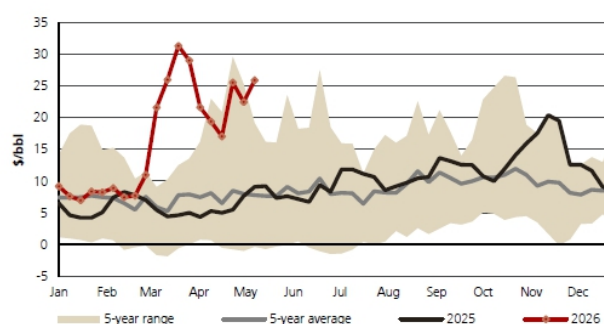
Source: General Administration of Customs of China (GACC)

Figure 13: Domestic refining margin



Source: Baiinfo. Note: Refining margin calculated using weighted average of output proportion, ex. VAT/consumption tax and including freight; oil prices on a 45-day lag.

Figure 14: European refining margin



Source: Datastream, UBS estimates

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Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 31 March 2026.

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